

FAITH THAT WORKS

A Study of the Book of James

By Daniel Tesfamariam

10 Week In-Depth Bible Study

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Scripture references from various translations.

For personal and small group study use.

INTRODUCTION TO JAMES

Author: James, brother of Jesus (likely written 45-50 AD)

Audience: Jewish Christians scattered among the nations

Theme: Genuine faith produces genuine works

Key Verse: 'Faith without works is dead.' - James 2:26

OVERVIEW OF JAMES:

Chapter 1: Trials, Temptation, and True Religion

Chapter 2: Favoritism and Faith & Works

Chapter 3: Taming the Tongue, Two Kinds of Wisdom

Chapter 4: Worldliness, Humility, and Planning

Chapter 5: Patience, Prayer, and Restoration

HOW TO USE THIS STUDY:

1. Read the passage at least twice before answering questions
2. Observation: What does the text SAY?
3. Interpretation: What does it MEAN?
4. Application: How do I APPLY this to my life?
5. Pray before and after each session

WEEK 1: TRIALS & WISDOM

James 1:1-8

James opens with a shocking command: 'Consider it pure joy when you face trials.'

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What does James say trials produce? (v. 3-4)

Q: Why does James connect trials to wisdom?

Q: What conditions does James give for receiving wisdom? (v. 5-6)

Q: What does 'double-minded' mean in this context?

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 1: TRIALS & WISDOM (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

Write a prayer responding to what God has shown you:

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

1. What stood out to you most in this passage and why?
2. How does this challenge or comfort you?
3. Where do you see this principle in your own life?
4. How can our group support each other in applying this?

NOTES:

WEEK 2: TEMPTATION

James 1:9-18

James distinguishes between trials (external) and temptation (internal desire).

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: How does James describe the progression of temptation? (v. 14-15)

Q: Why does James emphasize God does NOT tempt us?

Q: What is the 'crown of life' promised to? (v. 12)

Q: What do verses 17-18 reveal about God's character?

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 2: TEMPTATION (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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NOTES:

WEEK 3: HEARING & DOING

James 1:19-27

Faith that is real shows up in daily life - quick to listen, slow to speak.

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What three commands does James give in verse 19?

Q: What is the 'mirror' illustration about? (v. 23-25)

Q: What does James define as 'pure religion'? (v. 27)

Q: How does 'getting rid of moral filth' (v. 21) relate to hearing the Word?

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 3: HEARING & DOING (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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WEEK 4: FAVORITISM

James 2:1-13

James confronts the sin of showing partiality based on wealth or status.

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What example does James use to illustrate favoritism? (v. 2-4)

Q: Why is favoritism inconsistent with faith in Christ? (v. 1)

Q: What does James say about God's view of the poor? (v. 5)

Q: How does the 'royal law' relate to favoritism? (v. 8)

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 4: FAVORITISM (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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WEEK 5: FAITH & WORKS

James 2:14-26

The most debated passage in James - what is the relationship between faith and works?

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What kind of faith does James say CANNOT save? (v. 14)

Q: What illustration does James use in v. 15-16?

Q: How do Abraham and Rahab demonstrate faith WITH works?

Q: How do you reconcile James with Paul's teaching on grace?

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 5: FAITH & WORKS (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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NOTES:

WEEK 6: TAMING THE TONGUE

James 3:1-12

Small but powerful - the tongue can bless or destroy.

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What three metaphors does James use for the tongue? (v. 3-6)

Q: Why does James say the tongue is impossible to tame? (v. 8)

Q: What inconsistency does James point out? (v. 9-12)

Q: What responsibility do teachers have? (v. 1)

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 6: TAMING THE TONGUE (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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WEEK 7: GODLY VS WORLDLY WISDOM

James 3:13-4:10

Two kinds of wisdom produce two kinds of living.

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What are the marks of worldly wisdom? (v. 3:14-16)

Q: What are the marks of heavenly wisdom? (v. 3:17-18)

Q: What causes fights among believers? (4:1-3)

Q: What does 'friendship with the world' mean? (4:4)

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 7: GODLY VS WORLDLY WISDOM (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

Write a prayer responding to what God has shown you:

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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WEEK 8: PLANNING & PRIDE

James 4:11-5:6

James warns against arrogant planning and exploitation.

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What does James say about judging others? (4:11-12)

Q: What is wrong with the merchants' plans? (4:13-16)

Q: What principle does 4:17 establish?

Q: What warnings does James give the rich? (5:1-6)

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 8: PLANNING & PRIDE (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

Write a prayer responding to what God has shown you:

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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WEEK 9: PATIENCE IN SUFFERING

James 5:7-12

In light of Jesus' return, James calls for patient endurance.

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What illustration does James use for patience? (v. 7)

Q: Why does James mention the prophets and Job? (v. 10-11)

Q: What does 'the Lord is compassionate and merciful' mean here?

Q: Why does James mention swearing/oaths in this context? (v. 12)

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 9: PATIENCE IN SUFFERING (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

Write a prayer responding to what God has shown you:

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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WEEK 10: PRAYER & HEALING

James 5:13-20

James closes with the power of prayer and community restoration.

READ the passage at least twice. Then answer:

OBSERVATION - What does the text SAY?

Q: What does James prescribe for different situations? (v. 13-14)

Q: What role do elders play in healing? (v. 14-15)

Q: Why confess sins to one another? (v. 16)

Q: What does it mean to 'turn a sinner back'? (v. 19-20)

INTERPRETATION - What does it MEAN?

What is the main point James is making in this passage?

WEEK 10: PRAYER & HEALING (continued)

APPLICATION - How do I APPLY this?

What is one specific way I can live this out this week?

What do I need to change, start, or stop?

PRAYER:

Write a prayer responding to what God has shown you:

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS (for small groups):

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NOTES:

MY JAMES JOURNEY SUMMARY

Looking back over 10 weeks with James:

The biggest lesson I learned:

How my faith has grown:

Changes I've made:

What I want to continue studying:

But be doers of the word, and not hearers only. - James 1:22

May your faith produce works of love.

Keep studying. Keep growing. Keep doing.

- Daniel Tesfamariam